

4.2.2 Elements of political and social protest writing

Although it could be claimed that all texts are political, what defines the texts here is that they have issues of power and powerlessness at their core, with political and social protest issues central to each text's structure. The political and social protest genre covers representations of both public and private settings.

All set texts foreground oppression and domination and they all look at the cultures we live in and have lived in over time. A crucial word in the title of this option is 'Elements' and students need to consider the specific elements that exist in each of their texts. The elements that might be explored, depending on each individual text, include:

- the type of the text itself, whether it is a post-modern novel, science fiction, satirical poetry, historical and political drama
- the settings that are created as backdrops for political and social action and the power struggles that are played out on them. Both places (real and imagined) and time settings will also be significant here
- the specific nature of the power struggle, the behaviours of those with power and those without, those who have their hands on the levers of power
- the pursuit of power itself, rebellion against those with power, warfare
- the workings of the ruling political classes
- corruption, conspiracy, control
- the connection of the smaller world to the larger world
- the focus on human organisation: domestically, in the work place, in local and national governments
- gender politics and issues of social class
- the structural patterning of the text, how political tensions are heightened and perhaps resolved
- the way that language is used in the worlds that are created
- the way that political and social protest writing is used to comment on society, particularly the representation of society at particular historical periods
- ultimately how political and social protest writing affects audiences and readers, inviting reflection on our own world.

Students study **three** texts from the following list: **one** post-2000 prose text; **one** poetry text and **one** further text, **one** of which must be written pre-1900.

Author	Text	Time period
Margaret Atwood	<i>The Handmaid's Tale</i>	
William Blake	<i>Songs of Innocence and of Experience</i>	Pre-1900
Jim Crace	<i>Harvest</i>	Post-2000
Charles Dickens	<i>Hard Times</i>	Pre-1900

Author	Text	Time period
Tony Harrison	<i>Selected Poems</i> 'V', 'National Trust', 'Them and [uz]', 'Divisions', 'Working', 'Marked with D'	
Khaled Hosseini	<i>The Kite Runner</i>	Post-2000
Henrik Ibsen (Translated by Michael Meyer)	<i>A Doll's House</i> (Methuen Drama Student Edition 2008)*	Pre-1900
William Shakespeare	<i>Henry IV Part I</i>	Pre-1900

* The edition of *A Doll's House* which must be used is the Bloomsbury Methuen Drama edition, translated by Michael Meyer. We will treat the translated text as Ibsen's own words for assessment purposes.

As with all the requirements around genre/dates in this specification, a text can fulfil more than one category. So, for example *Songs of Innocence and of Experience* covers the requirement for a poetry text and a text written pre-1900.

We do not expect to change texts within the first five years of the specification. However, texts will be reviewed each year starting in September 2017 and we will give at least nine months' notice of any changes prior to first teaching of a two year course. The criteria for changing texts will be where a text becomes unavailable or where we can no longer use it in a question paper. Notice of any change will be communicated via our exam bulletins and aqa.org.uk/english